Action-Grounded Symbols: Abstracting Symbols from Skills in a Mobile Robot

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2026

Abstract

Key words: artificial intelligence, abstract symbols, computational cognitive science

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1 Introduction

Imagine an embodied agent - a robot. We want it to complete a task for us. It has a library of ready-to-use skills. To complete the task, the robot needs to execute those skills in correct order. But, for slightly different task, or in different circumstances, some skills may be unnecessary, or the order needs to be change. We want our robot to smoothly adapt to changing environment and objectives, and only focus on what is important for specific skill.
Take a closer look at the skills. A skill is a list of low-level actions, that can be executed by this robot. Their execution ends either successfully, or fail at some action. Obviously, the robot should execute a skill only when it can assume that the execution is going to be successful. For that each one comes with a precondition. A precondition is a symbol that says "You can do this skill now". This symbol is a predicate resolvable by examining the perceptual state of the robot. Robot can take a look around and decide if a skill is save to execute. Then, after skill execution, the robot changes its perceptual state, either by changing something in the environment, or changing its location. This new state is another predicate: an effect. Since the robot is supposed to execute skills successfully, only effects of those are of any interest to it. Then robot uses those predicates to establish which skills needed to be done, and in which order to complete assigned task. The aim of this project is to let the robot learn those predicates on its own.
This project is a replication of the work of Konidaris et al. (2018). The project's high-level idea and philosophical problem at a basis are identical to those of Konidaris'. I introduced some minor changes to the implementation in order to facilitate replication and, at crucial aspects, get closer to biological accuracy.
As a result... The conclusion is...

Paper's structure

Chapter 2 of this paper present theoretical grounds, and assumptions behind this project. In philosophical parts (2.1 and 2.2), it explain, why learning is done on embodied agent, and what is the problem that the implemented algorithm tries to solve. Then, in chapter 2.3, the reader can find the reason, why the robot gets preprocessed data in place of raw sensory inputs. Chapter 2.4 is about a structure used for resolving and saving predicates.
In chapter 3, the algorithm is described as a high-level idea, with no implement-specific details. Whereas, implementation is shown in chapter 4.
Chapter 5 show obtained symbols, and results for completing the task, as well as learning statistics. Chapter 6 discus those results, and indicate future steps for this project.

2 Theoretical Grounds

In this project embodied agent abstracts grounded symbols as a Growing Neural Gas (GNG) representations. Embodiment, the symbol grounding problem, and GNG have been around since the 1990s. So why still bother? Because embodiment was not contradicted, symbol grounding problem not solved, and even though GNGs have their optimised successors, the basics still stand the ground. I have chosen those methods to simplify the unimportant and focus on showing, how abstract symbols can come from simple actions and methods.
This chapter shortly introduces the theoretical grounds. First, I explain why it is necessary to take into an account not only the robot's brain, but its body and environment as well. For this, I briefly discuss what embodiment is. Next, I present the Symbol Grounding Problem, followed by the matter of symbol emergence. This concludes the philosophical core. Then, I explain the perceptual space. The dimensions in it are defined by robot's sensors and preprocessing of raw sensory data. The perceptual space dictates how the representations can be expressed. First, I focus on the dimensions and why the agent receives preprocessed sensory data. The inspiration comes from visual processing. Second, I cover a method for representing learned symbols and explain why I have chosen Growing Neural Networks for this.

2.1 Embodiment

According to the movement of embodied cognition, embodiment is inseparable part of the cognition (Varela et al., 2017). This stands in opposition to more classical cognitive science, representing computational theory of mind, where brain is a processor that handles abstract informations (Pylyshyn, 1984).
As a way to formalise the term of embodied cognition, Wilson (2002) introduced the six views. It is six statements (list them all???) that define what it means for the cognition to be embodied. In the context of this project the most interesting one is the fifth, although rest of them are also fulfilled.
Fifth view: Cognition is for action. This means that the mind's function is to guide action. Every mechanism, process or representation within the mind has to come from the need of planning or executing actions. Mind's main task is to control the movement of the body in an environment and ensure its survival.
The movement of embodied cognition is founded, among others, on the theory of affordances by Gibson (1977). His theory states that we perceive the world in terms of what can be done, how can we interact with an environment, or, as used in this project, what skill can be executed. For example, perceiving a door is seeing them as an object that can be opened and passed through.
Embodied cognition is criticized. Radical version of embodied cognition is easily disproven. For example, by the poverty of stimulus argument, which states that there is not enough information and structure in environment to solve cognitive problems (Miłkowski, 2017). Miłkowski settles on a hypothesis that for cognition both realms are important, embodiment and computations. Embodied experimental designs do lead to interesting discoveries, but not all cognitive processes can be explained by it.
This project focuses on what embodiment can do. The agent learns to perceive an environment in terms of predicates such as 'can-run-Open_the_Door'. Those predicates closely resemble Gibson's affordances and are learn by continuous interaction with an environment.

2.2 Symbol Grounding Problem and Symbol Emergence

Symbol Grounding Problem (SGP) was introduced by Harnad (1990). His starting point is computational theory of mind that looks at a brain as open-loop computing machine that operates within symbol systems. He drew attention to the meanings of those symbols, arguing that any interpretation for them, must be extrinsic to the system. He compares understanding such symbols to learning Chinese solely from the Chinese dictionary. Every attempt to find a meaning leads only to more symbols, that still lack the meaning. The Grounding Problem revolve around this. It asks the question if there is a mechanism that allows finding the meanings of symbols without escaping the system, therefore making them intrinsic to it. This is one side of the problem, in a context of robotics and cognitive modelling, the essential challenge is not symbol grounding. The most interesting problem there is symbol emergence: not only how to find the meaning of existing symbols, but how meaningful symbols arise, evolve, and become organized through social and embodied interaction (Taniguchi, 2026).
Harnad himself proposed a solution to SGP (Harnad, 1990). The mind grounds symbols in environment by creating iconic and categorical representations. It is a mechanism of associating the sensations with objects causing them. An object is then described in terms of sensory projection: as an representative point in perceptual space (an icon) or multiple points' invariants (a category). Even though, Harnad do not point out what triggers this mechanism, Peirce's pragmatism effectively addresses this issue. It ties objects and their characteristics with actions they are associated with (Kato, 2026). For example, a door is described as something that can be opened.
This and other solutions, from different angles, were proposed, yet the problem stays opened. Taddeo and Floridi (2005) conducted a review of 15 years of solving SGP. They concluded that explanations rely on pre-installed or other way given semantic resources.
This project also is dependent on external structures and symbol manipulations. But symbols essential for operating within an environment are obtained by repetitive discovery of possible sensory projections and binding them to the actions. Each action's precondition and effect has its iconic and categorical representations. The later is written in a form of Growing Neural Gas (GNG) projected on perceptual space, while the first is a representative point from nodes in said GNG. Those symbols are used for action, not communication, so social interactions are omitted in this project.

2.3 Sensory Input: Visual Processing

Biological sensory input is processed through neural paths before it reaches the brain. Even there, this early processed input can be further manipulated. (Crick & Koch, 2003). The robot under consideration has two types of sensors: LIDARs and RGB camera. Since humans do not posses anything remotely similar to the LIDARs, I focus on the vision.

The subject of recognising colours is described by Livingstone and Hubel (1988). They described how the eyes and the brain analyse visual input. Colour is perceived by the cells in the retina called cones. There are three types of cones: red-, green- and blue-sensitive. This is enough to distinguish between colours.

Another type of processing that happens at retinal level is detecting the differences in light saturation. They allow us to see the edges of objects in our visual field. Those cells are called retinal ganglion cells, and they form receptive fields. A receptive field has two areas: the on-centre and the off-centre. If the on-centre cells perceive more photons than the off-centre ones, the on-centre is activated. If the off-centre perceives more, the off-centre is activated. If both perceive the same amount, there is no activation (Kuffler, 1953).

Kuffler assumed some things that were proven wrong. First example is the linearity of the ganglion cell receptive fields. Enroth-Cugell and Robson (1966) proved that this is an oversimplification. Complete linearity means that the linear change in lighting is translated to the linear reaction of the cells in full input range. Yet some receptive fields are more sensitive to darkness, some to brightness.

Another example of known flaw in Kuffler's model is the laboratory setting of creating it. Keffler used tiny spots of light on anesthetised cat's retina. Yet in natural condition, the lighting changes, the eye moves. Later it was proven that the receptive fields adapt dynamically to those changing conditions (Smirnakis et al., 1997). Even though Keffler's model is a huge oversimplification, it is still a basis for the next models. I decided to use this simple model in this project, since it is a proof of concept.

For this project, the visual information from RGB camera matrix is translated to activation of red, blue, and green cones, and activation of on-center and off-center fields. Such preprocessed visual information is passed further to the symbol emergence algorithm.

2.4 Symbol Representation: Growing Neural Gas

TO BE DONE

(Ritter & Kohonen, 1989) (Fritzke, 1994) The representations as such...

3 High-Level Idea

To Be Updated

This project focuses on abstracting grounded symbols and using them for planning action. To achieve this goal, the starting point is a framework developed by Konidaris et al. (2018). The algorithm implemented and methods used slightly differ from the original, all in attempt of getting closer to biological accuracy.
Broadly speaking, abstract symbols emerge from preconditions and effects of skills executed by robot in an environment. These symbols are represented in perceptual space then used for abstract planning. To fully focus on symbols we assume that skills are already coded (or learnt) and that we are able to distinguish between a successfully executed skill and a failed attempt. To give agent's actions a structure, there is a task to be completed. The achievement of this task is also verified externally. This means that the learning is supervised, yet programmer do not determines what symbols are going to be learned in other means than choosing skills and the task. The utility of said symbols is presented in planing and executing a said task using PDDL language. Yet, both planing and executing is not a point of its own for this project.
The algorithm is heavily inspired by Konidaris et al. (2018), but it differs in number of places. Inspirations for those changes mostly come from the desire to model biological functioning more accurately, but some are just simplifications. The differences:

- The agent and the task are simplified in order to facilitate the programming of skills and shorten the time needed for simulation. Additionally, this can show that the symbols are specific to the shape, sensors and actuators of the agent, but a method is universal.
- There is no exploring and exploiting phases. The agent is consistently collecting unexpected data, and updates its symbols in batches. This resemble the activity of biological agents, including sleep patterns. (not explained earlier, is it a problem?)
- Instead of collecting all the precondition and effect data, each is represented by its own GNG network. Those networks are based on neural networks so have better biological accuracy than clusters of data. GNGs are updated on the data that is unexpected, for example an agent succeed in region that GNG indicates as a failure.
- Original work find the possible transitions between options by clustering data using DB-SCAN. This project calculates the coverage by checking how many GNG points from effect land within the precondition symbol.

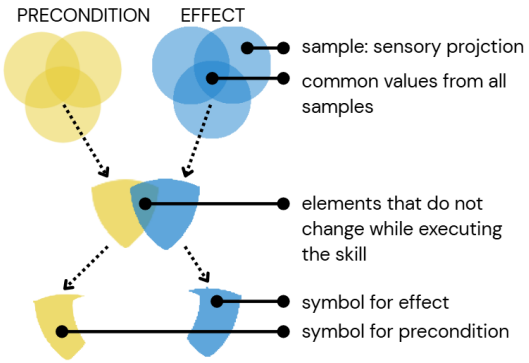


Figure 1: Visual guide to abstracting symbols from collected data. A symbol is a subspace of perceptual space that stays invariant through all the executions of a given skill, and is changed in consequence of executing given skill.

3.1 Abstracting The Symbols

3.2 Algorithm Description

Most important parts of the algorithm are shown on figures 2 - 6 as a flowcharts. *Main Loop* is the core of functioning, it controls execution and learning. I explain the program while referring to the flowcharts in following subsections. The description of the program's operation is divided into three parts: first loops, successful operating, and case analysis.

First loops

First step in the main loop (Figure 2) is to generate a plan, but at the very beginning, for every predicate: precondition or effect, there is no GNG. This means that the plan will not be generated, since no precondition of any skill is satisfied (Figure 3). Empty, invalid plan leads to exploration. This subprocess randomly choose skill from all the skills available to the agent and executes it (Figure 4). Here is the most important role of the *Supervisor*. It oversees the execution and returns if the skill was completed successfully (the result). The state of a robot is read before and after the execution (Figure 5). This information is most crucial for abstracting symbols. The result and evaluation of the predicate label the execution either as expected or not. The collected perceptual states from unexpected executions are used to update the predicates: both precondition and effect. In the first loops predicates are almost always unsatisfied, so execution of any skill leads to updating them - the agent starts to learn.

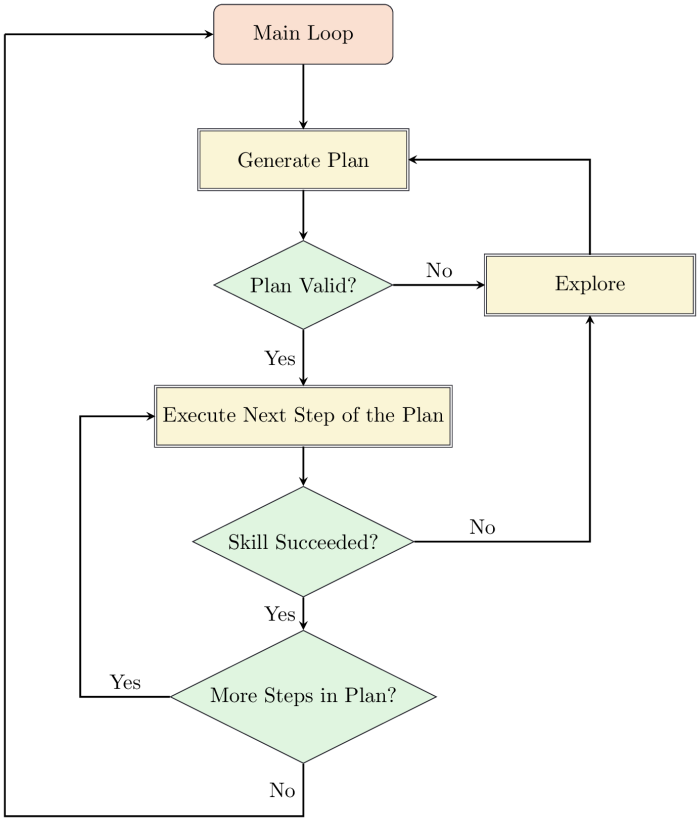


Figure 2: Main Loop Flowchart: The flowchart represents main loop of the program allowing to explore the environment and exploit gathered knowledge.

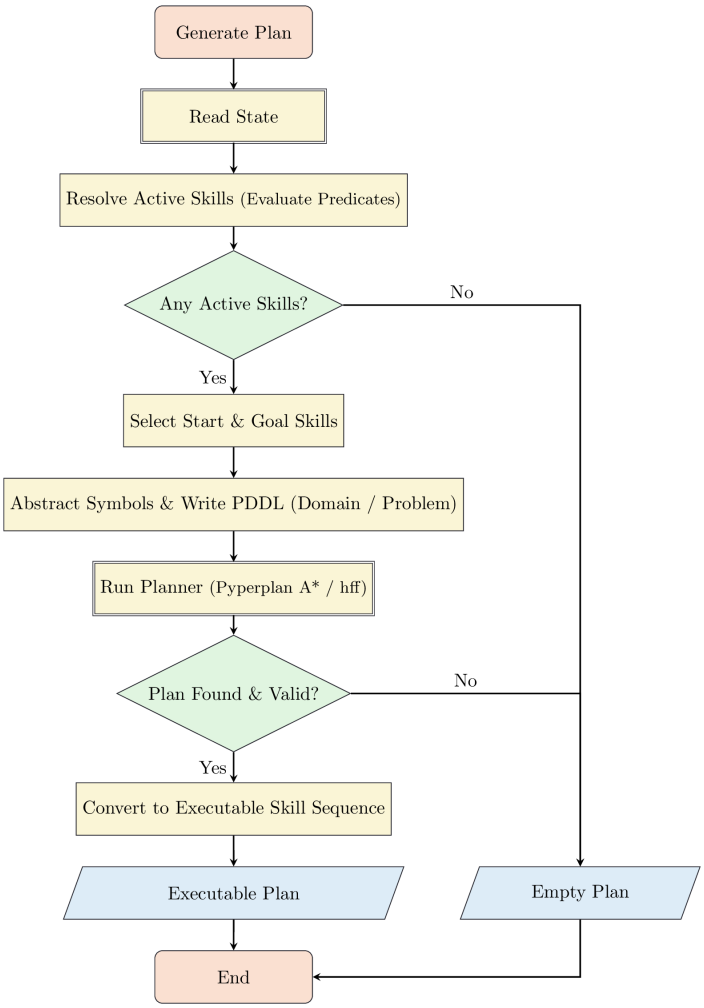


Figure 3: Generate Plan Flowchart: Flowchart for process of generating executable plan. It includes abstracting symbols from Growing Neural Gas Predicates.

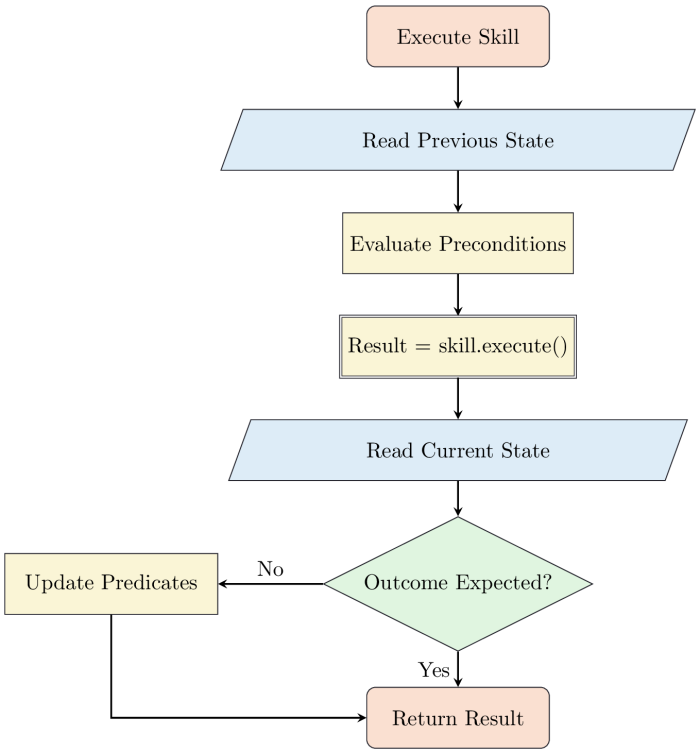


Figure 4: Execute Skill Flowchart: Flowchart for a process allowing executing chosen skill and collecting necessary data for updating Growing Neural Gas predicates.

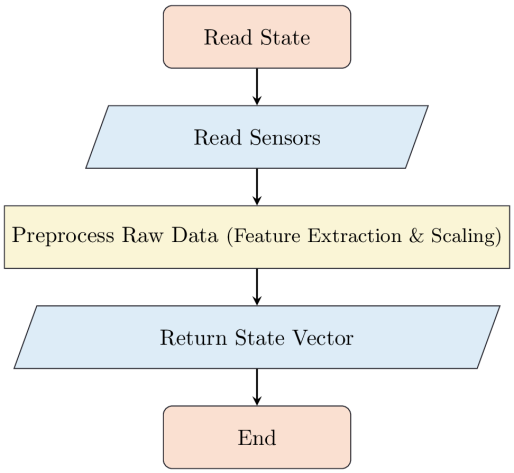


Figure 5: Read State Flowchart: Flowchart for a process of reading current state. It includes identifying current state in Growing Neural Gas network and assessing if known symbols' conditions are satisfied.

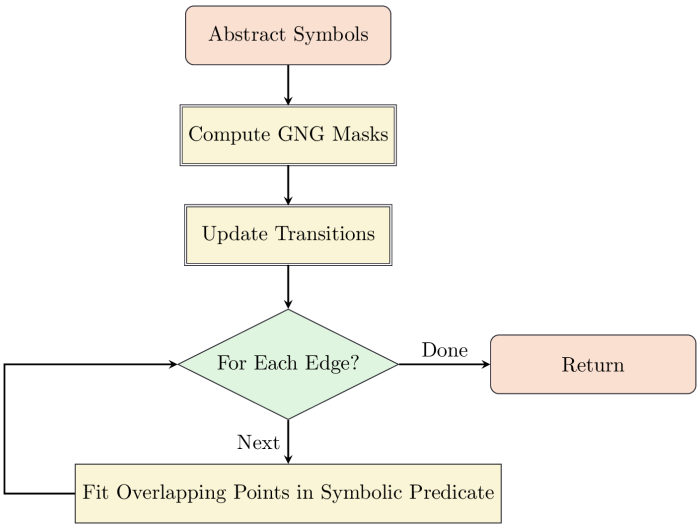


Figure 6: Abstract Symbols Flowchart: Flowchart for process of abstracting symbols at the junction of two skills (transitions). It is obtain by determining the common hyperplane in perceptual space.

Successful Operating

Once the agent learned enough that some preconditions are active, the plan can be generated (Figure 3). Agent chooses start randomly from any active option. Then it chooses a goal from all available options. Then the PDDL files are generated. For this transitions and their symbols are needed. Abstracting symbols creates symbols for transitions between skills. For each pair of skills, if all the points in effect GNG of preceding skill land within the precondition GNG of following skill, the symbol is created. This is because if executing the preceding skill results in the precondition being fulfilled, the following skill can be executed successfully. (But those symbols are useless, so let just say that the abstracting is continuous) Once all the symbols are ready, the domain.pddl and plan.pddl can be generated. Then, assuming that there is a path between the start and the goal, the plan is generated as a list of skills to be executed one by one. The agent executes them, and go back to the planning.

Case Analysis

Failed to execute a step of a plan
If an agent fail to execute a step of a plan, he simply add this to the updating data, and go back to exploration. During early steps this is often the case, because transitions are based on few examples.
New skill added
Adding a new skill to a trained agent does not require modifying old predicates. Transitions are automatically recalculated whenever predicates change, including when a new one is introduced. This way, the agent can operate with changing objectives
What should be added?

big change - need to change a lot of this

4 Implementation

Algorithm is implemented in Python using PyBullet simulation. The program keeps the simulation and the logic completely separated. This way the simulation keeps the realism of operating within the real environment. Thus the program consists of three main part: simulation, agent and supervisor. Each module is run in separate thread, mimicking the ROS nodes. Modules communicate through the bus, using services and broadcasting.
Simulation module generate the environment and control physics. Supervisor module has the knowledge about the simulation an the robot. It knows absolute position of the robot in the room as well as currently executed skill.
Agent module has implementations of operating logic, abstracting symbols, updating predicates, and low-level skills.
This chapter provides an overview of the system architecture and the methods employed in the implementation. The full source code repository is available online (Skorupowska, 2026).

4.1 Environment

A robot is a simplified version of e-Puck 2 (Figure 7). It resembles its shape and have the same set of sensors and actuators. The only actuators are two differential wheels, which makes the robot to move non-holonomically. The sensors are: 8 LIDARs with range from 0 to 10 cm and a RGB camera with matrix of 120×160 pixels.

The arena (Figure 8) for the task consist of two rooms separated by the wall. Each room has different coloured floor so the robot is able to different between them using only its sensors. In the separating wall there is a contrasting door. The door swings open on the push of the robot. Robot's task originate in orange room, then in second room, the blue one, there is contrasting post, which robot is supposed to reach.

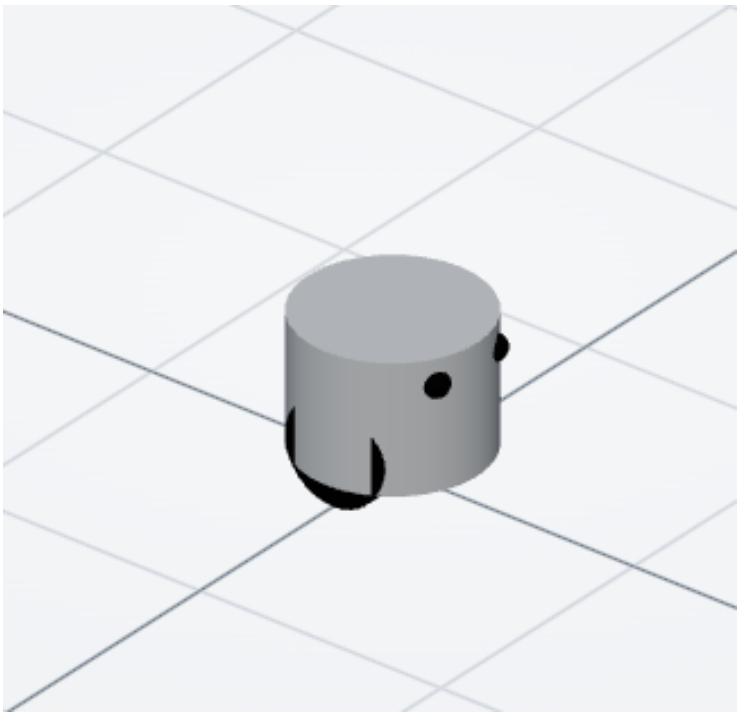


Figure 7: Simplified model of an e-Puck 2 as cylinder body with differential wheels. Eyes added purely for aesthetics.

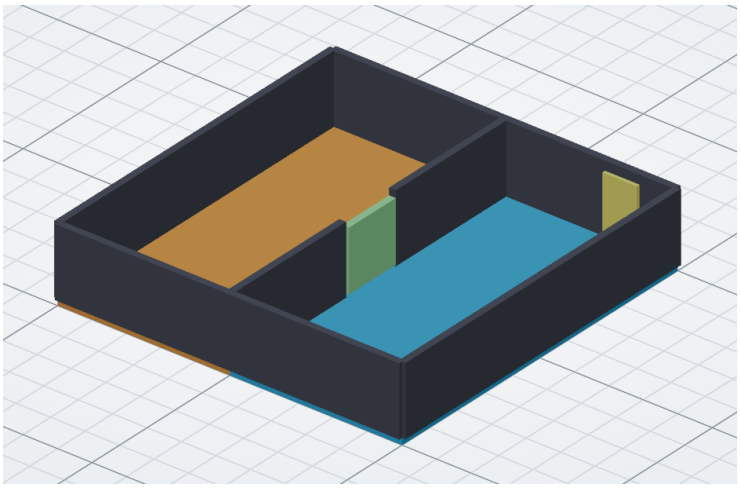


Figure 8: Model of an arena used in the simulation. Two rooms separated by a wall with the door.

4.2 Supervisor

Next module updates the data for all the debugging figures and answers robot's questions through the bus. This is the implementation of supervision within the learning. The supervisor has knowledge beyond robot's perception and can modulate both the environment and robot. The main task of a supervisor in the learning process is checking if a skill was executed successfully, Each skill has some conditions of success and failure. This is similar to what is being learned, but the difference is that those are formulated in terms of the outsider. The outsider can have different sensors or simply different point of reference. For example, the supervisor knows in which room the robot is, the robot does not. The skill 'start' can be executed anywhere, has no precondition, but is finished successfully only if the robot is in the orange room. Supervisor checks this condition and returns to the agent if it succeed.

4.3 Agent

This module consist of the main logic loop, the networks for predicates and transitions, and low-level skills.

Predicates

Predicates are represented by Supervised Growing Neural Gas. These are implementation of basic GNG Fritzke (1994) with added behaviour for negative points. The original algorithm was for unsupervised learning, and mapped space from collected points. Since the execution can be successful or not, I added a reverse logic for negative points, symmetrical to treating positive ones. If a point considered is positive, the neural gas points are pulled to it. If it is negative, they are pushed away. add parameters with explanation for them

Transition graph

The transition graph is represented by a standard directed graph. It plays no role in the learning process. This graph is used for generating PDDL files. The transitions are collected from the overlapping points of effects and preconditions and generated after each update to either of them.

PDDL files

PDDL files are generated by simple, structural code. Each time the predicates are updated, the new problem and domain files are generated. The domain file (Listing 2) defines the world for an agent. What can be seen (predicates) and what can be done (actions). In this domain there are as many actions as skills, and for each skill two types of predicates: can-run-skill and executed-skill. This way we cover both starting conditions for a skill and its effect. The problem file (Listing 1) specify the domain and the predicates that are fulfilled at the beginning and the predicates that need to be fulfilled at the end.

```
(define (problem plan_problem)
  (:domain robot_domain)
  (:init
    (can_run_Start)
  )
  (:goal
    (executed_Finish)
  )
)
```

Listing 1: Problem definition in PDDL

```
(define (domain robot_domain)
  (:requirements :strips)
  (:predicates
    (can_run_Open_the_Door)
    (executed_Open_the_Door)
    (can_run_Start)
    (executed_Start)
    (can_run_Finish)
    (executed_Finish)
    (can_run_Go_to_the_Goal)
    (executed_Go_to_the_Goal)
    (can_run_Go_to_the_Door)
    (executed_Go_to_the_Door)
    (can_run_Find_the_Door)
    (executed_Find_the_Door)
    (can_run_Find_the_Goal)
    (executed_Find_the_Goal)
  )

  (:action Open_the_Door
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Open_the_Door)
    :effect (and (executed_Open_the_Door) (can_run_Find_the_Door) (
    can_run_Find_the_Goal) (not (can_run_Open_the_Door)))
  )

  (:action Start
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Start)
    :effect (and (executed_Start) (can_run_Find_the_Door) (not (
    can_run_Start)))
  )

  (:action Finish
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Finish)
    :effect (and (executed_Finish) (not (can_run_Finish)))
  )

  (:action Go_to_the_Goal
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Go_to_the_Goal)
    :effect (and (executed_Go_to_the_Goal) (can_run_Finish) (
    can_run_Find_the_Door) (can_run_Find_the_Goal) (not (
    can_run_Go_to_the_Goal)))
```

```
  )

  (:action Go_to_the_Door
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Go_to_the_Door)
    :effect (and (executed_Go_to_the_Door) (can_run_Open_the_Door)
    (can_run_Find_the_Door) (not (can_run_Go_to_the_Door)))
  )

  (:action Find_the_Door
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Find_the_Door)
    :effect (and (executed_Find_the_Door) (can_run_Go_to_the_Door)
    (not (can_run_Find_the_Door)))
  )

  (:action Find_the_Goal
    :parameters ()
    :precondition (can_run_Find_the_Goal)
    :effect (and (executed_Find_the_Goal) (can_run_Go_to_the_Goal)
    (not (can_run_Find_the_Goal)))
  )
)
```

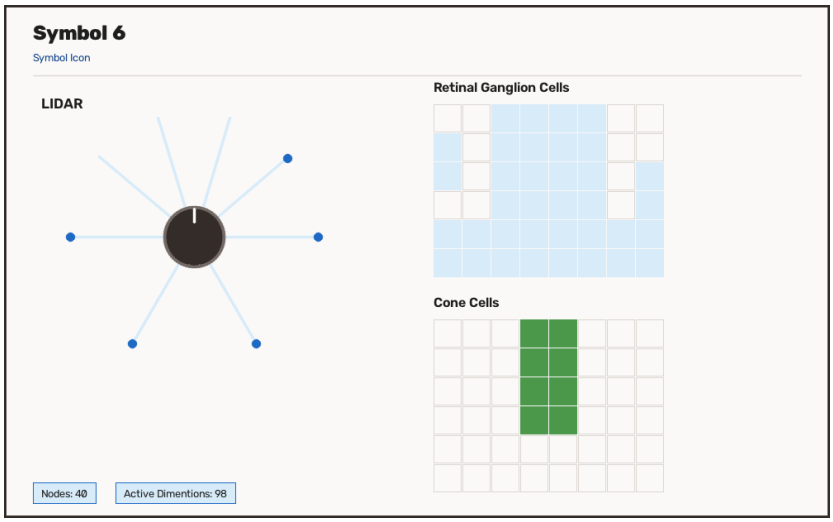
Listing 2: Domain definition in PDDL

Visual Preprocessing

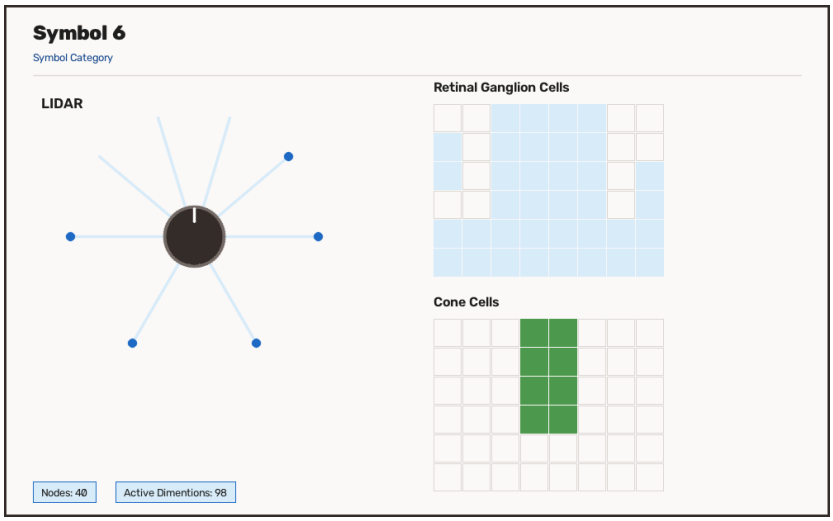
Low-level Skills

5 Results

The main results of this project are symbolic preconditions and effects. Appendix **??** holds all obtained symbols. Figure 9 shows two types of representing 'Finish' skill precondition. First type, the iconic representation (fig. 9a), shows median point of the GNG. Second type, the categorical representation (fig. 9b), shows the invariant dimensions for all the points in GNG. In this example, we see that to be able to finish successfully, the robot has to see yellow panel in front of him.



(a) Iconic representation



(b) Categorical representation

Figure 9: 'Finish' skill precondition symbolic representation. Two types of visualising obtained symbols: iconic and categorical.

Those symbols are the result of executing the main loop 32,216 times in 10 sessions. Within those executions was exploration as well as planning. The brain was updated 12,887 times. Figure 10 shows the frequency of brain updates through time. This shows that the more the agent knows the less frequent the updates are.

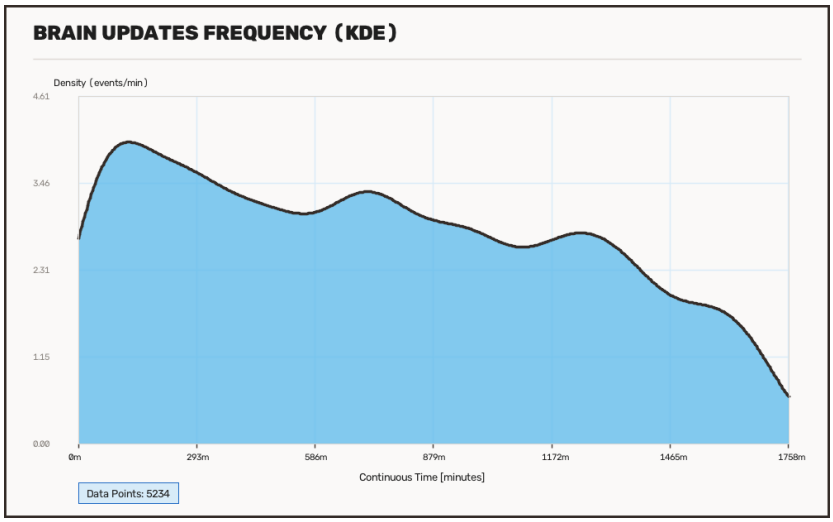


Figure 10: Update frequency through all the sessions. For calculating the update density (frequency) the Kernel Density Estimation (KDE) was used.

The symbols dictate possible transitions between skills. As mentioned before, the transition is possible if an effect of preceding skill is within the precondition of following one. Figure **??** shows the transitions deducted from the predicates. In given task the robot searched for the path from 'Start' to 'Finish'.

Tests

For testing the planning was executed with fixed goal skill set to 'Finish'. The starting skill was chosen randomly among the active ones.

6 Discussion

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